to this latter category, so did M A Vellodi, who was additional secretary in the department of space.

Vellodi was to the point and did not like unnecessary formalities. Once he accompanied Dhawan to the US, and on their return stopped over at France to visit us. It was our monthly custom to have a pot lunch, where every scientist's family would bring a dish and we would meet at one of the houses. That day it was Mohana Prasad's turn to host lunch. Mohana Prasad kept asking Vellodi if he can serve him a second helping of rice. Vellodi said 'no'. When, after a few minutes, Mohana Prasad asked him the same question, Vellodi snapped: I told you no. If I want something, I will help myself.'

Vellodi was also a stickler for time. At any meeting, he would be there a minute in advance. But what surprised me more was that he would also fold his files and leave the meeting at the scheduled time even if the meeting was going on. This was more so during lunch time.

He kept his composure at all times—even after a bad car crash that left Vellodi and A E Muthunayagam, my immediate boss and head of Auxiliary Propulsion Systems Unit, injured in 1972. After a visit to Sriharikota, I had returned to the guest house in Madras by evening. When Vellodi and Muthunayagam, who were also at Sriharikota, did not return to Chennai till late night, I made some calls. I was told their car had met with an accident on the highway, and the two were admitted to the Government General Hospital, Chennai.

I rushed to the hospital. Muthunayagam was to soon fly to the US to present a paper in Louisiana. Muthunayagam, in a state of sedation, was speaking incoherent things; doctors said it was trauma-induced. Vellodi appeared composed.

It wasn't medical miracles all the way in France. Scientist S C Ghosh's wife delivered a stillborn, a few more fell ill, but we managed the situations with the corpus fund. Finally the government provided the medical cover, which still wouldn't have been adequate to cover the expenses in a case like that of Panda.